

The Fair Weight

by Douglxss Burley Johnson

Pull that dry willow in closer before the river damp gets into it. The Lehigh is right there past the weeds, black under the Race Street Bridge lights, and once the sun drops behind the Whitehall ridge the cold comes up off the water like it owns the bank. We're on the Catasauqua side, on the flat where the old towpath used to run, and if you listen you can hear a truck shift gears on Howertown Road and a freight somewhere south of us headed toward Bethlehem. My name is Miles Keiper. I'm twenty-four. This is about a floor scale at a scrap yard, and about a word my shift lead kept borrowing when he had no right to it.

I was twenty the summer I worked the counter at Kehler Metals. The yard sat on West Race Street behind a beverage distributor, a chain-link lot with piles of copper and aluminum and a corrugated office that smelled like hot metal and the coffee that sat on the burner from open until close. Mr. Kehler came in at eight, counted the cash drawer, and left the floor to whoever had the shift. That summer the floor belonged to Vince Rutt, twenty-eight, thick through the

shoulders from dragging motors, with a tattoo of wrenches and a skull on his forearm and a habit of calling every customer buddy whether they liked it or not.

Vince was good to me in the way a man is good when he wants you to owe him. Over the first weeks he walked me through the grades, bright copper and number two and insulated, and showed me how to strip a refrigerator without cutting your knuckles open on the sharp edge of the back panel. The Friday I got my first full week in, he bought me a cheesesteak from the place on Bridge Street, and we ate it on the loading dock with grease on our wrists and the river heat coming through the fence.

You need to know how Vince talked about fair.

"Fair is what you can get away with and still sleep," he told me the second week, while we waited for a pickup to clear the scale. The line landed like a joke and like a rule at the same time. "The state doesn't care. Kehler doesn't care if the ticket looks clean. Wrong is what gets you caught. Ought is whatever keeps the drawer from coming up short on you."

He used those words the way a man uses a borrowed ratchet: fair, wrong, ought, should. On the dock he told me a man should look out for himself, called it wrong when a customer tried to pass painted pipe as clean copper, and said a boss ought to cut the counter kid in when the numbers ran favorable. God, to Vince, was optional, a story for old women and funeral homes. The universe was atoms and luck and the check you took home Friday.

I did not argue with him on the dock. Arguing with Vince was like arguing with a running compressor. You got noise and you got heat and the work still sat there when you finished.

The scale was a floor platform with a digital head mounted on a post by the office door. Customers drove on with their loads, we printed tickets, and cash went out the window. The head

had a zero button under a plastic cover, and beside the post Kehler kept a certified fifty-pound test weight painted yellow, the paint chipped where boots kicked it over the years. The weight sat on a scrap of plywood so it would not dig a dent in the concrete. That plywood scrap had a coffee ring on it from a cup somebody left there in July. The coffee ring is one of the true things in this story, and it does no other work except sit there.

It was late August, a Thursday, an hour from closing, when a man named Ortiz pulled in with a truck bed of stripped copper wire, clean bright, the kind that pays. Vince met him at the gate. I was inside counting out twenties for a small aluminum ticket when Vince came through the office door and shut it with his hip.

"Ortiz is heavy," Vince said, voice kept low while the air conditioner in the window rattled. "I put the short under the left pad before he rolled on. Ticket will come light by about forty. We split the difference off the cash. Fair, right? He'll never know. He gets paid. We get paid. Kehler gets a clean book."

My hands stayed on the twenties. The drawer edge dug into my wrist.

Vince held up both palms, the wrenches-and-skull flexed. "Don't get church on me. There is no scorekeeper. Molecules don't care. You want to talk ought, you ought to take care of the guy who taught you the grades."

Outside, Ortiz sat in his truck with the window down and a Phillies cap low on his forehead. A wasp walked the edge of the office trash can. The digital head on the post showed a number I could not read from the window yet, and the yellow test weight sat on its plywood where it always sat.

I did not answer Vince with a speech. Speeches do not move a man who has already decided the universe is empty and the words he still needs are free for the taking. I walked out to the scale with the twenties still folded in my back pocket.

The platform had a thin steel shim under the left pad, the kind we used for leveling when the concrete heaved in March. Vince had slid it in so the pad rode high and the head read light. I crouched until my knees took the grit of the lot, pulled the shim free with two fingers, and set it on the concrete beside the post. Then I lifted the yellow fifty-pound weight onto the empty platform and pressed zero under the plastic cover until the head went still at fifty on the nose.

Ortiz watched me from the cab. Vince stood in the office doorway with his arms crossed and his mouth flat.

I waved Ortiz forward until the truck and the wire rolled onto the pad. The head climbed and settled. I wrote the ticket for the true number, counted the cash at the window, and put every dollar into Ortiz's hand. He tipped his cap once and pulled out toward Race Street and the bridge.

After the truck cleared the gate, Vince stayed on the lot with his boots planted in the dust.

"You just cost us," he said.

"I zeroed a scale," I said.

"You think that was wrong, what I did?" Vince came down off the doorway step, dust already sticking to the sweat on his neck. "Says who? You? Your pastor? There is no wrong without a rulemaker, Miles, and there isn't one. Fair is a word people invent so they can sleep. I borrowed it and I used it. Same as you just did when you decided what I ought not do."

He had me on the language and he knew it. The whole time my hands were on the shim, ought had been working in my head; wrong had lit when I saw the short; fair had ridden the zero button down. If Vince was right and there was no Lawgiver, then my hands had only followed a

preference, and his preference was as good as mine, and Ortiz's missing forty was only a shift in atoms from one pocket to another.

I stood with the yellow weight still warm from the sun in my palms. The certified stamp on the top face caught the late light. I set the weight back on the plywood coffee ring and flipped the plastic cover down over the zero button until it clicked.

"You used the words," I said. "Fair. Wrong. Ought. You used them like they meant more than your mood. Then you said the One who makes those words mean anything is optional. You can't keep the weight and throw out the stamp."

Vince laughed once through his nose. A motorcycle went over the Race Street Bridge and the sound folded into the river trees.

"Cute," he said. "You're preaching with a test weight."

"I'm telling you what my hands already did," I said. "You want fair to be real when a customer cheats you. You want wrong to be real when a man short-changes a drawer. You want ought when you tell me I ought to cut you in. Those claims need a Judge who does not change when the shift changes. Molecules don't write tickets. A borrowed rule still belongs to the Owner."

Vince picked the shim up off the concrete, bent it between his fingers, and tossed it into the scrap bucket by the fence. The bucket rang. He wiped his hands on his jeans.

"I still sleep fine," he said. "You keep your stamp. I'll keep my share next time you're not looking."

He walked back into the office and shut the cash drawer hard enough that the window rattled. I finished the close alone: swept the copper chips off the counter, locked the gate, and left the yellow weight on its plywood where Kehler would find it in the morning.

That night Vince texted me about a fire down by the river, the usual spot on the Catasauqua bank under the bridge lights. I went out of habit and unfinished business. We sat on overturned buckets with a ring of brick and scrap pine catching. Whitehall's strip glowed faint across the water to the west. A heron stood in the shallows and did not move when a train horn blew. Vince cracked a can. I kept my hands around a paper cup of gas-station coffee that had already gone lukewarm.

He did not bring up the scale right away. He talked about a girl in Coplay and a transmission job and a guy at the yard who always shorted his own lunch break. Then he tipped the can toward me.

"You still think God is watching the pad," he said.

"I think fair has to come from somewhere that isn't us," I said. "If it comes from us, then your short and my zero are the same kind of noise. You don't live like they're the same. You get mad when a man cheats you. Mad needs a real line."

Vince stared at the coals. The heron lifted and went upriver into the dark. A moth kept hitting the nearest bridge light and falling back and trying again.

"I'm not converting," Vince said, plain as copper grades. "I like the words. I don't like the Owner. You can keep pressing zero. I'll keep sleeping."

"I know," I said. "I'm not your Holy Spirit."

He drank. I watched the fire take a knot of pine and throw a short spark onto the brick, where it died. We did not hug it out. We did not settle the veil. The Lehigh moved past us toward Easton the way it always does, and Vince stayed Vince, and the yellow weight sat locked behind the office door on West Race Street with its stamp still true.

I quit Kehler Metals that October for a receiving job in a Whitehall warehouse where the clocks punch clean and nobody asks me to short a pad. Vince still works the counter. Sometimes I see his truck on Race Street when I cross the bridge. He lifts two fingers off the wheel. I lift two fingers back. We have not spoken about ought since the night under the lights.

On nights like this, with the willow smoking and the bridge humming and the river taking the day's heat off the bank, I keep the story short. I am not here to close the big question for you. I am here to tell you what a borrowed rule sounds like in a man's mouth when his hands are shorting a scale, and what another man's hands did with a fifty-pound weight and a zero button when the words ran out of room to hide.

Throw that other piece on. Let the fire see our faces. I like a Catasauqua fire that shows me the bridge and the water both, and leaves the far bank dark where the light can't reach.

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